

# TAKEOUT DOUBLES

## ABOUT THE DEALS

You will always be in the South position. Either you or partner may be the Takeout Doubler.

(Strictly speaking a Takeout Double is a **CALL**, not a bid, so the term is used loosely here.)

## TAKEOUT DOUBLE SUMMARY

*Note that the following really is just a Summary, not a full-blown lesson.*

The Takeout Double is one of the oldest conventions in Bridge.

In it's simplest form it means "Partner, I have a good hand, please pick a suit."

It is necessary that you and partner agree on when a double is for takeout, and when it is not. Here are some suggestions:

- The bid that is doubled is a suit bid, not notrump.
- Neither the Doubler nor his partner have made any call other than pass.
- The bid that has been doubled is below game level.

There are three categories of Takeout Double.

- The classic one where you have opening strength and support for all unbid suits.
- The one-suited hand which is too strong for an overcall.
- The notrump type hand which is too strong for a non-jump notrump overcall.

Here are the various guidelines:

|            |                                                                                                                                                            |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Classic    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• 13+ points*</li><li>• no more than 2 cards in doubled suit</li><li>• at least 3 cards in the other suits</li></ul> |
| One-suited | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• 17 or more points</li><li>• a quality suit 5 cards or longer</li></ul>                                             |
| Notrump    | <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• balanced notrump type hand</li><li>• more than 18 points</li><li>• good stoppers in doubled suit</li></ul>         |

\* When evaluating your hand for a Classic TO Double you may count short-suit points, just as if you were responding to partner's opening bid. The idea is that partner will be choosing a suit which you can support. Don't go overboard though, because partner really hasn't bid that suit yet!

You may disagree with all these guidelines, many will. By all means stick to yours. But if your partnership doesn't have an agreement then these are a good start. They are here because the Deals that follow are based on them.

### Classic Double:

The partner of the Takeout Doubler should assume that the double is of the Classic type because it usually will be. Then, if Doubler later indicates one of the other types he can adjust.

Partner's actions are as follows:

- 0-8 points or fewer - bid a suit at the cheapest level
- 9-11 points - jump in a suit
- 12+ points - cuebid the opponent's suit; forcing to game
- 8-10 points - bid notrump at cheapest level if balanced and with a stopper in opponent's suit
- 11-12 points - jump in notrump if balanced and with 1+ stoppers in opponent's suit
- 13-15 points - bid 3NT if balanced and with 2 stoppers in opponent's suit
- "some" points - pass for penalties holding 6 good cards in opponent's suit; partner is expected to lead a trump

The Doubler's next bid will be a natural bid dependent on his partner's response to the double. The 0-8 point range is the largest spread and so creates the largest problem for the Doubler, who should proceed cautiously.

### **One-suited Double**

If Doubler ignores partner's choice of a suit and bids his own suit that indicates he has the 17+ point type of Takeout Double. It shows an Overcalling type of hand, but one which is too strong to Overcall. Responder should then bid naturally based on the knowledge of Doubler's hand which is known to contain a good 5+ card suit.

### **Notrump**

Holding a 15-18 point balanced hand with a good stopper in the opponent's suit you would just overcall 1NT.

You show a 19+ point balanced hand by first doubling, then bidding notrump. Partner should proceed just as if you had opened 2NT.

### **Opener's Partner bids:**

If your partner makes a Takeout Double and the next player says anything other than pass then you are no longer required to bid. This is because your partner gets another chance to bid and doesn't have to let the opponents play the doubled (or perhaps redoubled) contract. So if you **do** bid in this situation it is called a "free bid", one that you weren't forced to make. With a bad hand you would probably just pass, but if you have a distinct suit preference you should say so immediately rather than waiting until the bidding gets to a high level.

The topic really merits another 25,000 words.  
Instead we have 25 examples.

Board: 1

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 1♥

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥2

Board: 2

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: East

Lead: ♦K

Board: 3

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3♥

Declarer: South

Lead: ♦A

Board: 4

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 2♠

Declarer: West

Lead: ♥K

**Board 1**

East Deals

None Vul

♠ J 8 7 3 2

♥ Q 7

♦ K 6 3

♣ A J 9

♠ K 5

♥ J 10 5 3

♦ 9 7 4 2

♣ 8 7 3



♠ Q 10

♥ 6 4 2

♦ A Q J 10 5

♣ K 4 2

♠ A 9 6 4

♥ A K 9 8

♦ 8

♣ Q 10 6 5

The bidding has been as shown.

You have a perfect hand for a Takeout Double. Singleton in their suit, 4-card support for the other three suits and 13 HCP. You Double. Partner responds 1♥. What do you say next?

Yes, you like the ♥s. But remember, you forced partner to bid and his response showed 8 or fewer points. You are not strong enough to consider a game so you pass.

*West**North**East**South*

1♦

Dbl

Pass

1♥

All Pass

1♥ by North

Lead: ♥2

**Board 2**

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K Q 10 4

♥ A K 9 8

♦ 8

♣ A J 6 5

♠ J 6 5 2

♥ 6 4 2

♦ J 3

♣ Q 10 7 2



♠ A 9 8 3

♥ Q J

♦ 7 6 5 2

♣ 8 4 3

♠ 7

♥ 10 7 5 3

♦ A K Q 10 9 4

♣ K 9

The bidding has been as shown.

Naturally you make a Takeout Double. Partner responds 1♠. What is your next call?

With 17 HCP and the singleton you are not strong enough to insist on game. On the other hand if partner is at the top of his 0-8 point range then game is likely. A raise to 2♠ invites partner to bid game with a maximum. Partner accepts the invitation.

| West       | North | East | South |
|------------|-------|------|-------|
|            |       |      | 1♦    |
| Dbl        | Pass  | 1♠   | Pass  |
| 2♠         | Pass  | 4♠   |       |
| All Pass   |       |      |       |
| 4♠ by East |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♦K   |       |      |       |

**Board 3**

West Deals

E-W Vul

♠ J 8 3  
♥ A 7 2  
♦ A 2  
♣ K 8 7 5 2

♠ A Q 4  
♥ K Q J 6  
♦ Q J 10 7  
♣ A 3



♠ 10 9 7 5  
♥ 9 4  
♦ K 9 5 3  
♣ Q J 10

♠ K 6 2  
♥ 10 8 5 3  
♦ 8 6 4  
♣ 9 6 4

| West         | North | East | South |
|--------------|-------|------|-------|
| 1 ♣          | Dbl   | Pass | 1 ♥   |
| Pass         | 3 ♥   |      |       |
| All Pass     |       |      |       |
| 3 ♥ by South |       |      |       |
| Lead: ♦ A    |       |      |       |

The bidding has been as shown.

With 19 HCP and a doubleton you certainly double.  
What do you bid after partner replies 1 ♥?

You need to make a strong invitation since partner needs very little for your side to have a game. So you bid 3 ♥. Partner has almost nothing so he passes.  
Good thing.

**Board 4**

North Deals

Both Vul

♠ K J 8 3

♥ Q 7 5

♦ 7 3

♣ K 6 5 2

♠ 5

♥ A K J 6 4 2

♦ K Q 9 6 5

♣ Q



♠ A Q 6 4

♥ 8

♦ J 10 8 2

♣ A 10 7 3

♠ 10 9 7 2

♥ 10 9 3

♦ A 4

♣ J 9 8 4

The bidding has been as shown.

This is certainly not a great hand, but at least the shape is good. You should strive to get into the bidding whenever possible, and with this hand the only way in is to double. Partner jumps to 2♠ and it is your bid again.

Partner shows 9-11 points and a ♠ suit. However, he didn't force you to game, and you barely scraped up the double to begin with. So you pass.

*West**North**East**South*

1♥

Dbl

Pass

2♠

All Pass

2♠ by West

Lead: ♥K